

Lesson 1 - Vedic period Vedas and their significance.

Learning objectives:

- 1] Understand the significance of the Vedic period in Indian history and culture.
- 2] Explain the major characteristics of the Vedic society.
- 3] Four divisions of the Vedas.
- 4] Recognize the spiritual and philosophical teachings of the Vedas.
- 5] Appreciate the relevance of the Vedas in contemporary times.

Topic 1 - Overview of the Vedic period

Namaskar friends, this year onwards you are going to study something called IKS. It is a novel idea to study the Indian knowledge systems, that is IKS. And we believe that the Indian knowledge systems go back to the Vedic period, to the Vedas. Now, when we talk about the Vedas, the question arises how old are they? So you must have heard or read somewhere that they are very old. But it is not possible to say only this vague concept of the Vedas. So we need to know the period of the Vedas. You will be surprised to know that scholars around the globe, either the Indian scholars or the Western scholars, have been trying to find out the exact period of the Vedas. However, they have not been successful in doing that. Let us try to know the commonly accepted period of the Vedas. Veda is the poetry of gods. The actual dating of the Vedas has been a subject matter of considerable debate. The latest date attributed by many modern researchers falls a few million before the common era, the Indian knowledge repository includes weights and predates the Western civilizational Grit knowledge repository by several millennia. Several works constituting the Indian knowledge belonged to 3000 BCE or before. It is very difficult to establish the historicity of the Indian knowledge system in general because the repositories were oral, that is, moukhik. Fortunately, in an era of information technology-driven research, a new light is being thrown on the historicity of Indian knowledge repositories, commonly accepted by scholars that the Vedas belonged to the time before the common era. Now, what is a common era that we should know about? Because you must have heard or read this idea before the common era and after the common era, or just the common era. So before common era means before Christ and common era means after Christ. In Hindi, it is called Isvisan or Isvisadi. In Marathi, it is called Isvisan Purva and Isvisan after the Isvisan. So that is how the time is calculated, and that is how the Vedas are

considered to belong to the time of 2500 years before the common era, or even 3000 years before the common era. And the oldest Veda, that is the Rigveda, is supposed to be the oldest one. And that is why it belongs to the first point of the timeline. And when you read the traditional thoughts, you will realize that the tradition believes that there is no beginning of the Vedas. They are anadi because they are considered ishvarasya nishvasitam. So actually they are born from the God, the Almighty. The God inhaled and exhaled, and the Vedas were produced. So that is the traditional belief. And just now we saw what the modern people believe. When we imagine that the Rigveda was composed somewhere around 2500 years before the common era, we can also see that there are multiple layers in the Vedic literature. You will come to know about it later. And there are approximately four layers which are considered. And you have to look at that period that it began at the point of 3000 years before the common era. And then gradually, the literature was composed. Now, when we look at the Vedas, especially the Rigveda, it is considered to be Apaurusheya, which means the tradition believes that no human being has composed it. It came into being naturally. And this is how we can look at the general timeline of the Vedas. Now, let's map out this ancient era on the timeline of history. The Vedic period extended from around 3000 to 500 BCE. Think of it like a long thousand-year marathon run that our ancestors embarked upon with each century representing a milestone. The distance between us and the Vedic period is quite vast, much like the long stretch between Delhi and Mumbai. But the footprints of this marathon continue to echo in our lives even today. One could describe the Vedic period as a blossoming garden of civilization. It was marked by significant developments in religion, philosophy, literature, and society. Just as a banyan tree starts from a tiny seed, but grows into a massive entity, the seeds of Indian culture sown in this period have grown into a colossal and diverse civilization. You. In terms of political organization, the Vedic period was characterised by small communities or clan-based structures. Think of these tribes as modern-day startups with leaders who were chosen based on their merits and abilities. These were not monolithic kingdoms or democracies, but smaller cooperative units of society, functioning under a leader, much like teams in a company. The Vedic society was stratified, but still quite fluid, like water in a river, constantly changing and adapting. There was a rudimentary division based on profession known as the Varna system. But this was a far cry from the rigid caste system that came in later periods. Once Varuna was based on their profession, not their birth, much like we choose our careers today. The cultural

significance of the Vedic period lies in its intellectual and spiritual contributions. It laid the foundational bricks for the grand edifice of Indian philosophy, literature, and spirituality. Just like a timeless story that is interpreted to influence many generations, the original ideas and concepts that originated in the Vedic period have echoed through the centuries, influencing Indian thought and culture to this day.

Topic 2 - Introduction to the Vedas

Do you know what is the meaning of the word Veda? Veda is derived from the Sanskrit root vid, which means to know. And therefore the word veda can be simply translated as knowledge. And therefore Veda means knowledge. But you might have heard that the Vedas are also called shrutis. Now, what is the meaning of the word shruti? Shruti means something which is heard because it is derived from dhatu, shru. It is a Sanskrit dhatu again, and it means to hear. Now, why are they called shrutis? Because the Vedas were always transferred from one generation to the other generation through the oral tradition, the Moukhiki parampara, as they call it. And you can imagine gurukula, an ashrama where the guru is chanting the mantras and they are transferred to the shishyas. The students, are also repeating it, and that is how they are memorising it. This is how the education of the Vedas was done and it Therefore. Therefore, What is Veda? Vedas, t That the ancient times. Even now you will see that there are some traditional pathshalas where the same tradition is followed. The word ved is derived from the Sanskrit verb vid, which translates to know or knowledge. So simply put, ved stands for knowledge. But this isn't any ordinary knowledge we are talking about. It's akin to the fundamental laws of nature, like gravity. Just as gravity helps us navigate the physical world, the Vedas guide us through life's spiritual and philosophical dimensions. It's believed that the Vedas are not creations of human intellect, but revealed texts. They are often called shruti, which means what is heard. Picture them as the cosmic instruction manual for humanity, said to be revealed to the ancient seers or rishis, seers, have been. Or have now, during their deep meditations. Much like a scientist who stumbles upon a discovery during an experiment. Consider the Veda as a vast library. Just like a library is divided into sections for better understanding. The Vedas are organised into four broad categories, Rigveda, Yajurveda, Samved, and Atharva Veda. Each Veda is further divided into parts like a book is divided into chapters dealing with different aspects of knowledge and rituals. The four divisions are like the four pillars supporting the edifice of Vedic knowledge. Rigveda, the first one, is like the root of a tree comprising hymns and chants. Yajurveda is like a

trunk containing ritualistic details. Sam Ved, akin to the branches, is a melody, the musical form of a hymns. Finally, Atharva VED, like the leaves, is a mix of spells, charms, and practical wisdom. Imagine these as the different layers of an onion. The outermost layer, the Brahmins, provides explanations of the rituals. The next layer, the Aranyakas, serves as a link between ritualistic and philosophical aspects. At their core lie the Upanishads, offering philosophical insights, much like the seed of an onion from which new understanding grows. The weights are to Indian literature and philosophy what the foundation is to a building. They have influenced countless aspects of Indian life, from arts, culture, and education to legal systems and ethical codes. Just as the Internet shapes modern communication, this Ancient wisdom continues to illuminate our paths. Just as a lighthouse guides ships in a vast sea.

Topic 3 - Rigveda: An overview

So, friends, you have seen which are the layers in the Vedic literature. And as I said, it starts with the Rigveda. So what is Veda? Rigveda is also known as Rigveda Samhita. So Rigveda is an ancient book, or rather the oldest book, which is available not only in India but is accepted as the oldest available literature throughout the world. And the word Rigveda can be dissolved as Rucham Vedah. So if the word Veda means knowledge or the word Veda means storage of knowledge, Rigveda means the storage of knowledge in the form of Ruchas. Now, what is a rucha, or what is a rook? Rook means a mantra. I'm sure you must have heard the word mantra many times. So this concept of mantra starts from the Rigveda. And here it is, the knowledge in the form of these mantras. These mantras were composed by the Rishis or the Drashtas or the seers to praise the deities. And this is how you can look at the word Rigveda. Now, when you look at the word Rigveda, you simply don't understand whether they are just mantras, but the mantras are arranged properly, and all these mantras are divided into ten mandalas, or you can say ten chapters. And it is interesting to know that chapter or mandala, two to seven, these mandalas are called family mandalas, Rishi mandalas, or Gotra mandalas. Why? Because all these chapters are assigned to a particular family. So, for example, number two is assigned to a family called Bruhadsamhita, or number seven is assigned to a famous rishi Vasishtha. I'm sure you must have heard his name. So this way, these mandalas are called family Mandalas. The first and 10th mandalas are a mixture of various mantras composed by different Rishis. There is a very special mandala in the Rigveda that is number nine, and it is devoted to a special deity called Soma. The soma here does not mean the moon, but a very famous Vedic deity. And this is

how we can look at the Rigvedic composition arrangement of Rigveda. Imagine standing at the foot of a towering mountain of knowledge. That's what we experience when we explore the Rigveda. Often considered the oldest of all Vedas, formed during 2500 BEC, Rigveda is like the heart of Vedic literature, housing a repository of hymns dedicated to the pantheon of Vedic gods. It's as if you are at a museum of ancient wisdom, capturing the very genesis of human thought. And philosophy. Rug means appraising mantra. Rigved means knowledge in the form of mantras which praise the gods. Much like the intricate pattern of a rangoli during Diwali, the Rigveda comprises beautifully composed hymns divided into ten mandalas or books. Each mandal is made up of suktas or hymns, just like a beautifully woven fabric, each thread contributing to the larger pattern. It's like standing in a labyrinth, where each turn is a new hymn, adding to the beauty and grandeur of the overall piece. Six of the ten books are ascribed to a particular family of the Rishis. If we consider the Rigveda as the grand canvas, then its themes are like vibrant hues of human existence. These themes include devotion to gods, the concept of rucha, or cosmic order, social life, and various philosophical ideas. Some hymns from the Rigveda also throw light on contemporary society, like Krushi sukta. Imagine it as an ancient classroom where universal principles and moral conduct were taught, forming the groundwork for the moral compass we adhere to today. Think of the Rigveda as a river whose waters have nourished the fields of Indian culture and society over millennia. It shaped the religious practices, social norms, and philosophical thoughts of ancient India, much like a potter molding a pot on the wheel. Just as you can't imagine India without its vibrant festivals and traditions, the Indian culture is unimaginable without the imprint of the Rigveda. Consider the Rigveda as a timeless text, like the constitution of a nation. Though penned thousands of years ago, its teachings resonate with us even today, guiding us on the paths of righteousness and moral living, just like the North Star guiding sailors at sea. It's as if we have a treasure trove of wisdom from our ancestors, guiding us through the convoluted corridors of modern life. Rigveda's verses are like timeless pearls of wisdom. Consider the Gayatri mantra, a profound vocation for illuminating our intellect. These verses are like ancient lamps shedding light on our path even in the darkest of times.

Topic 4 - Yajur Veda: An overview

So, friends, now let's know what is Yajurveda. Yajurveda comes in the second place of the Samhitas. The way we try to define the Rigveda, we shall also define the word Yajurveda. It can be defined as Yajusham Vedah. Now, what is a Yajur

or what is a Yajus? Theoretically speaking, rukh or rucha and Yajus, both are mantras. But the Yajur mantras are different from the rook mantras. The Rukh mantras were composed to praise the gods, and the Yajur mantras were composed to apply in the yajnas. I'm sure you know what is a yajna. It is broadly translated as a sacrifice or a Vedic ritual. And when these yajnas were performed, these Yajur mantras were chanted by a person called Adharyu. And in the Yajurveda also, we see that there are two traditions, very famous traditions. One is called Shukla Yajurveda, and the other one is called Krishna Yajurveda. In the Shukla Yajurveda, you find only mantras, whereas in the Krishna Yajurveda, you find a mixture of prose and poetry, the mantras as well as some prose part. Let's dive into the Yajurveda, one of the four Vedas that make up the world's oldest texts. Picture it like an ancient book of rituals detailing the ceremonies that were fundamental to the society of that era. Its name is derived from the Sanskrit words Yajus, meaning sacrificial formula, and ved, meaning knowledge. Therefore, Yajurveda can be loosely translated as knowledge of the sacrificial formulas. Imagine Yajurveda as an ancient manuscript, a sort of instruction manual with prose and verses. It is divided into two significant parts, the shukla, or white Yajurveda, and the Krishna, or black Yajurveda. The distinction is similar to two different editions of the same book, with each having its unique characteristics and teachings. The Yajurveda primarily focuses on rituals and sacrifices performed in the Vedic times. Just as we have rules and regulations for today's events, from cricket matches to parliamentary proceedings, this VeD laid out the rules for religious and social ceremonies. The teachings are intricate, providing procedural details for conducting the rituals, akin to how modern cookbooks detail recipes. The Yajurveda was like the societal rulebook of the Vedic period. Its influence can be compared to how the Constitution impacts our contemporary society, shaping rituals, customs and social norms. It was through this Veda that various rituals and sacrifices became standardised and formed an integral part of the social fabric. Wondering about the Yajurveda's modern relevance, think of it as a window into the past, offering insights into our ancestor's beliefs and practices. While we may not follow the specific rituals today, its principles of discipline, devotion, and meticulousness can still inspire our contemporary work ethics and spiritual practices. The Yajurveda is filled with verses that hold universal messages. For instance, a popular verse may all beings look to me with the eye of a friend, and I look to all beings with the eye of a friend encapsulates the

timeless ethos of empathy and camaraderie, relevant even in today's interconnected world.

Topic 5 - Sam Veda: An overview

- so now let us know about the Sama Veda. The Sama Veda comes at the third place in the order of the Samhitas. Before we talk about Samveda, let me tell you that the Rigveda, Yajurveda and Samveda are also called tri. Tri means a trio, a group of three. And why they are called tri? Because all of them were totally or closely associated with the yajnas, the Vedic sacrifices. So what is the duty of the Sama Veda? What is the role of the Samveda? Similar to the definitions of the words Rigveda and Yajurveda, the definition of the word Samveda is sam nam veda. So what is a saman? The word saman can be popularly translated as a melody. So Samveda is the knowledge or the storage of knowledge, which talks about the melodies. Now, what is the connection between the mantras and the melodies? The connection is this. When you look at the text of the Sama Veda, we realize that 75% of the mantras are taken from the Rigveda to the Sama Veda. So content-wise, there is not much novelty. But the speciality of Samveda is this melody or samantha. The Rigvedic mantras were sung in such a way that the same mantras had a different form in the Sama Vedic tradition. And when you look at the Samveda, you can realize that there are two parts of the Samveda. The first one is called Purvarchika, and the second one is called Uttara Chika. Purva means the first and uttara means the later or the second one. In the Sama Vedic chanting, there is one more speciality, and that is also called aranyagana and gramagana, or Aranyagayan and gramagayan. So while chanting the Samveda, the traditional people chant some part of the mantras in those particular melodies. In the grama, grama means the human habitation in the villages, in towns, but certain part was considered mystic, and therefore it was sung only in the Aranya, which is the forest away from the human habitation. And these are the special features of Samveda. One more thing which we must know, that is Samveda is considered to be the origin of the world-famous Indian classical music. And out of the seven swaras, we find six swaras in the Samveda. Welcome to our journey into the sam veda, often termed the ved of melodies sam means melody in English. This beautiful aspect of the Vedic literature forms the basis of Indian classical music. Much like the root from which a grand banyan tree grows, the sam ved, a collection of verses taken mostly from the Rigveda, is set to melodious tunes, serving as a gentle reminder that our ancestors sought to express their spirituality not just through words but also through the harmonious language of music. The Samveda is

composed of two parts, the Purva archika and the Uttar archika. Similar to the two halves of a football field, each with its unique role, the Purva archika includes verses to be sung during the first part of the Soma sacrifice ritual, while the Uttar archika comprises those for the remaining part of the ritual. Just as you can't imagine a football game without both halves, the soma sacrifice ritual is incomplete. Without verses from both the Purva Chika and the Uttara Chika, the sam ved is not just a hymnal it also contains profound teachings. Much like a melodious teacher imparting wisdom in song, it focuses on worship and rituals, specifically the Soma sacrifice, teaching us about the importance of sacrifice, devotion, and the role of rituals in society. If the Rigveda is the brain of the Vedas, the Sam Veda can be seen as the soul, emphasising the emotional devotional aspect of spirituality. Just as Bollywood had significantly influenced Indian popular culture, the Sam Veda has left an indelible imprint on Indian classical music. Enchanting, it introduced the concept of musical notes, scales, and melodic structures, forming the base upon which the elaborate edifice of Indian music stands today. Even the chanting style used in many spiritual practices across India can be traced back to the sam ved. In today's fast-paced world, where life often feels like a hundred-meter sprint, the Samved, with its emphasis on music, offers a respite. Its melodious hymns can guide us towards inner peace and harmony, teaching us the value of pausing, reflecting, and appreciating the music of life. It also continues to inspire musicians, serving as a timeless muse, a testament to the universality and eternal relevance of its message. A few key verses from the Samved beautifully encapsulate its essence. For instance, one verse says, let your deeds be noble with your heart attuned to righteousness, sing with joy to the divine. This message, simple yet profound, speaks to all of us, echoing the timeless truth that a life lived in harmony with the divine and our fellow beings is a life well lived.

Topic 6 - Atharva Veda: An overview

we now turn our attention to the Atharvaved, the fourth and final member of the illustrious Vedic quartet. Unlike the other three Vedas, which mostly focus on rituals and philosophical musings, the Atharvaved is a diverse collection of hymns, charms and spells. It is in many ways the ancient Indian version of a practical guidebook, brimming with remedies for common challenges in life, as if you found an ancient manuscript containing tips and solutions for everyday problems alongside profound spiritual insights. Atharvaved is like a river with many tributaries, each carrying its unique wisdom. It's organised into 20 books containing around 730 hymns and 6000 verses in total. Each hymn is akin to a

chapter in a modern self-help book dealing with different subjects like healing spells, domestic rituals and more. One could say that the Atharvaved is the Swiss army knife of the Vedas. Its teachings range from healing diseases to warding off evil spirits to attracting prosperity. Much like diverse applications in a modern mobile app, this practical side of the VeD can offer valuable insights into the everyday life of ancient India, giving a richer understanding of our history and culture. Atharvaved can be seen as the ancestor of Ayurveda, India's traditional system of medicine. Analogous to the DNA shared between parent and child. It provides us with various treatments intended to cure illnesses and ensure well-being, reflecting the ancient Indians' understanding of health and disease. Imagine it as an old wise doctor passing on his knowledge. In our age of advanced science and technology, Atharvaved still holds relevance. Its profound spiritual teachings, akin to an old lighthouse still guiding ships, provide us with a way to deal with modern challenges. Its knowledge of herbal medicines and chants can be seen as a source of inspiration for researchers and scholars alike. The Atharvaved is a treasure trove of wisdom and knowledge, with verses dealing with many aspects of life. For example, one hymn addresses the earth praising its fertility and bounty. This is reminiscent of today's efforts to appreciate and protect our environment, underlining the timeless relevance of Vedic wisdom.

Topic 7 - Spiritual Teachings of the Vedas

Friends, you must be thinking that the Vedas are nothing else but the mantras and the praise of the gods and something which is employed in the Vedic yadnyas. But it is not the reality. We can also take some more interesting ideas, and concepts deep rooted in our society from the Vedas. For example, Rita, Rita is an astonishing concept found in the Rigveda. I'm sure you know the word Rutu. Rutu means a season, and Rita means something which is disciplined. It is. Or it can be broadly translated as a cosmic discipline. The Vedic people believed, and the Vedic mantras proposed, that nature, the deities, the human beings and everything else, all need to follow that cosmic discipline that is Rutha. And no one can be independent of this rutha. And they believed that this leads to a stable and happy life. When you go through the Vedic suktas, that is the group

of mantras, you will also understand that the Vedic people believed in many deities. Even now we know that there are multiple deities in present Indian religions, including the Hindu religion. And the same can be seen, or rather, it can be traced back to the Vedas, that there are multiple deities and they were praised by the devotees or the seers or the Rishis. But again, I must tell you that there was a gradual journey from the multiplicity of the deities towards the soul deity, towards the ultimate principle. And how did it happen? When you read the sukta, when you read the group of mantras, you realize that the Seer or the Rishi praised one deity at one time. So if it is an Indra sukta, that is the prayer to God Indra, Indra was regarded very high, and all his brave acts were praised in that sukta. Therefore, we can say that although there were multiple deities, every time, they were focused on one single deity. And there are some more sukta where you can see that they believed that although there are many deities, they have only one single power. So the power is common, and the might is common among all gods. Therefore, here is one mantra, and that is from the third mandala of the Rukveda. It says, mahat devanam Asuratvam, Ekam. I must tell you that the word asuratva here does not mean anything related to the demons. The word asuratva means the power or the strength. And even if there were many devas, many gods, the asuratva or the power was only one. And as we go ahead, we can also see that from the first mandala of the Rigveda, there is a very famous mantra. It says, Akam satvipraha, bahudha, vadanti, which means vipraha. The wise people, they know that there is only one sat. The word sat here means reality. There is only one reality. But wise people know that reality is in multiple forms. Bahudha, that is multiple forms. And this is how we can see that there was a gradual transformation of beliefs throughout the Vedic text. When you read about the tradition or the ancient ideas, the ancient society, you must have heard about the concept of moksha, and you must be wondering, what is it? So let me tell you. Although the Vedas are the oldest texts in our tradition, we do not find the exact concept of moksha or liberation, or emancipation in the oldest Vedas. But they had their own set of beliefs, and that was like this. They felt that death was not the end of the world or end of the life. And they believed that there is a life after death. Either you go to heaven if you perform good deeds, and if you perform bad deeds, then you go to the Yamaloka. That is the abode of Yama. But I must tell you that there was no concept of Naraka or hell in the earlier Vedic texts. So even if you go to the Yamaloka, you are not harassed the way you imagine about the hell. The Vedas form the bedrock of Indian spirituality, but it's not simply about divine worship.

Instead, picture it like the roots of a tree reaching deep into the soil of ethical living, philosophical introspection and the pursuit of knowledge. It is akin to the way the Internet connects us to a world of information, except this spiritual network connects us to profound inner wisdom. Dharma, karma, and moksha are like the fundamental laws of physics that govern this spiritual universe. Dharma, akin to the Constitution of India, outlines the moral and ethical duties for a fulfilling life. Karma is like the principle of cause and effect. For every action, there's an equal and opposite reaction. Moksha, in simple terms, is akin to graduation day, symbolising liberation from the cycle of life and death. After learning all life's lessons, imagine the universe as a grand, intricate web of interconnected realities, with the divine essence being the thread that weaves this web together. God in the Vedas is not a singular entity, but rather the underpinning cosmic energy pervading all creation, much like how electricity powers every gadget and appliance we use. Vedic rituals and ceremonies might appear as complicated as learning how to code for the first time. However, each ritual has a symbolic meaning, creating a language of spiritual expression like performing a multistep scientific experiment. These rituals are designed to induce mindfulness, discipline, and a sense of communal harmony. Liberation, or moksha, is not a destination to be reached but a journey to be experienced. It is the equivalent of achieving true mental well-being in today's language, unburdened by worldly attachments and liberated from the cycle of desire and discontent. This is akin to a perfectly balanced equation where inner peace equals outer harmony. In an era where mental health is getting as much emphasis as physical well-being, the spiritual wisdom of the Vedas resonates deeply. Imagine if you had an ancient wellness manual offering tools to navigate stress, uncertainties, and emotional turmoil. That's what the Vedas can be for modern times, a guide for cultivating resilience, empathy, and spiritual well-being.

Topic 8 - Philosophical Insights from the Vedas

So now we try to understand something about the Vedic philosophy when we talk about the traditional Indian philosophy, I'm sure, or you might remember the word Upanishads. But you must have understood by now that Upanishads are almost at the end of the Vedic tradition. And at the moment, we are talking about the earlier layer of the Vedas. So the Upanishads came later. In the earlier layers of the Vedic texts, we find still some indications of the origin of the world. It is also known as cosmogony. And there are very famous suktas in the Rigveda. The oldest Veda, for example, Nasadiya Sukta. This sukta starts with something

like this. Nasat asit, na asat asit. So you can see the seer or the rishi was perplexed about the situation. He said there was no existence and no nonexistence. It's a very mystic kind of supta. And then he goes ahead and he says that everything was filled with the water, and there was one single germ in that water which came up, and from that, something was created, and then everything was created. There is one more similar sukta in the Rigveda itself. It is called Hiranyagarbha Sukta. The word hiranya, garbha, hiranya means gold or golden, and garbha means embryo. So this Sukta tells us that in the beginning of the world, there was only a golden egg, a golden fetus. And you know that the new life comes up from an egg. So this is the idea which you see in the Hiranyagarbha sukta. And some people have interpreted that this Hiranyagarbha, or the golden Fetus, is nothing else but the sun. The sun is the origin of the energy, the source of energy for us even today. And therefore, everything, all over the world, was originated from the Hiranyagarbha. This is how multiple ideas, varied ideas, can be seen in the Vedas, regarding the idea, or rather to the query of where this world comes from. Where from I have originated. So these were the answers different Rishis tried to find out. Welcome to the world of Vedic philosophy, an age-old wellspring of wisdom that continues to inspire thinkers and seekers globally. The underlying essence of Vedic philosophy is not about prescribing a single rigid path, but rather encouraging individual spiritual journeys. It's like a guiding star in the dark, showing direction to each on a different journey towards their respective destinations. Imagine the universe as an ocean and each living entity as a drop of water. In Vedic philosophy, Brahman represents this cosmic ocean, the ultimate reality or absolute, while Atman signifies the individual self or soul. The water drop, the ultimate realization, lies in understanding the unity of Atman and Brahman, much like recognising that a drop of water shares the same essence as the vast ocean. The Upanishads, often referred to as Vedanta, or the end of the Vedas, serve as a philosophical compass. Imagine them as a series of profound dialogues akin to a modern day podcast where spiritual gurus address the existential questions of their students. These dialogues cover a myriad of topics, from the nature of reality to the path of self-realisation. Offering insights still applicable in today's world. Maya can be thought of as a virtual reality headset, creating a world that seems real but is essentially a luxury. It's the veil that obscures our vision of the ultimate truth, Brahman making us believe in the temporary physical world as the absolute reality. This Vedic concept challenges us to look beyond the apparent and question our perceptions, a thought that

finds echoes in modern philosophical and scientific debates. The Vedas introduce the concept of reincarnation and Sansar, often compared to an endless cycle or a wheel of birth and death. Think of it as an infinite game where each round signifies a lifetime, and the game continues until we achieve moksha or liberation. This philosophical perspective encourages us to see beyond the constraints of a single life, urging ethical living and spiritual growth over multiple lifetimes. The ripple effect of Vedic philosophy is visible in contemporary thought across various domains, be it the mindfulness movement, the popularisation of yoga, or the pursuit of sustainable living. It's like an ancient tree whose roots lie in the weeds, but whose branches spread into modern society, offering shade and fruit to anyone willing to rest or nourish beneath it. Through these teachings, we gain a deeper understanding of our place in the universe and our interconnection with all forms of life. Close.

Topic 9 - Vedas and Society

As we know, the word Veda means knowledge, and this knowledge can be of various types. So when we read the Vedas, we also come to know about the social structure in ancient India, and we can find scattered references to the social structure in the Vedas. In the grand canvas of the Vedic period, society was envisioned as holistically connected, a concept often likened to the functioning of a human body. Each part had a specific function and contributed to the greater good. People were grouped into various classes, or varanas, based on their skills and vocations. A bit like how, in a modern society, we categorise people as engineers, doctors, artists and all, emphasising the interdependence of each role. The Vedas laid down certain norms and customs for the functioning of society, just as we have rules and laws in our societies today. To maintain order, the Vedas proposed principles like truthfulness, charity and nonviolence. Some customs might feel distant today, like the detailed ritualistic sacrifices. But the core idea of maintaining societal harmony persists, like a consistent thread in the fabric of our society. So when we talk about ancient society, I'm sure you must have heard that the ancient society was classified in something called the Varna system. And let us know that there is a clear difference between the varnas and the castes. The Varanas were originally based on the skills of the people. And the way we know that some people are doctors, some people are teachers, some people are engineers, some people are artists. That is, we know today in the same way, these varnas were based on the skills of the people. So, for example, a person has a particular skill in Vedic studies, and he can also teach the Vedas to the students. He was categorised as a Brahmana, someone who

knows the Brahma and hears the word Brahma means knowledge again. So that is why he was called Brahmana. Then there was another Varana called Kshatriya. You know, Kshatriya means the king. These kings became kings because they had the skill of protecting the people and setting the society's incorrect law and order. There were vaishas who used to do trade, and there were shudras. Probably they had different skill sets. Probably they were artisans, and they were making different necessary commodities in life. So this is how the Varna system was not very rigid in the Vedic times. I will give you an example. We saw some time back that the Rigveda is divided into ten chapters. Now, when we talk about the third mandala of the Rukveda, that mandala where we have the famous Gayatri mantra, Bhargodevasya dhimahi dhiyo yona prachodayat. That particular famous Gayatri mantra comes from Mandal three. Now, who was the seer of this mandala? The seer of this mandala was Vishwamitra and Vishwamitra was Akshatriya. But he was not compelled to become a king. He could become a rishi. And this is how you can see that there was no rigidity in the earlier layers of ancient Indian society. When we talk about society, we should also note that the kings were not only the monarchs. They had their people, they had their assistants who used to assist them in various capacities. So they used to have mantri or they used to have a senapati. And more than that, there was something called sabha and samiti. By referring to the various Vedic references, we can understand that these sabha and Samitis were a group of people where ideas were discussed and the king was bound to listen to them. We also come to know that the queen of the king or the prince of the king, of them, was involved in royal activities and activities related to law and order. The Varana system, often understood as a precursor to the caste system, was a social stratification based on profession and aptitude. It was somewhat analogous to our modern occupation-based societies but with more spiritual undertones. While this system did form the bedrock of societal organization, it's important to remember that it was intended to be fluid and mobility was possible, quite unlike the rigid caste system it later morphed into. Women enjoyed high status in Vedic society, not unlike the increasing recognition of women's rights and gender equality. In contemporary India. There were women's scholars, seers, and poets, a reflection of the significant value attached to their contributions. As society transformed over time, women's status varied. But the early Vedic period provides glimpses of a more gender-balanced society. Economic activities during the Vedic period were largely agrarian, similar to how agriculture still forms a major part of India's economy. Crafts and trade were also prevalent. Like

our modern industries and commerce sectors, society thrived on interdependence, highlighting the concept that everyone from the farmer to the merchant contributed to the economic wheel. The transition from Vedic to post-Vedic times is much like watching a city evolve over centuries. In this evolution, the societal fabric changed, cities emerged, political structures evolved, the varna system hardened into a more rigid caste system, and economic activities became more diverse. As we traverse through history, we observe how societal norms, customs and structures from the Vedic period, though modified, continue to influence Indian society today.

Topic 10 - Relevance of Vedas in Contemporary Times

Friends, you must be wondering that it is fine that we have these age-old Vedas and they are the pioneers of our tradition. But what is the relevance of the Vedas in present times? Are they relevant even after these many thousands of years? We must think about the Vedas in this way. The Vedas are the solid rock behind our age-old tradition, history and culture. They are the beginning of the famous Indian heritage. Everything which you find in the Vedas is reflected in the later forms of literature, philosophy, thoughts and the ethos, the entire ethos of our society. Not only this, the points like Sabha and Samiti, which I told you a few minutes ago. You can see a similar division of the centers of power, or rather the centers of policymakers in present society too. So you can certainly connect the old ideas, the Vedic ideas of Sabah and Samiti, and the present ideas of the groups or the levels of our policymakers. Just as you navigate your way around a new city using online maps, consider the Vedas as ancient guides to the cosmos and nature's laws. Despite being thousands of years old, they explore advanced concepts such as cosmic cycles, consciousness and the underlying unity of existence. Today, as quantum physics and cosmology probe these very questions, the Vedas stand as a testament to our ancestor's scientific insights, opening avenues for intriguing dialogues between ancient wisdom and modern science. Indian arts and literature, like the mighty river Ganga, have been significantly shaped by the currents of Vedic wisdom. Think of the Vedas as the seed from which the great tree of Indian art, poetry, music and dance has grown. Just as Indian cinema today explores diverse themes, the Vedas, too, delve into an extensive range of human emotions and experiences, providing a timeless source of inspiration for artists, writers and thinkers. Spirituality in the modern world, much like a shopping mall, offers numerous paths to explore as the Vedas, like the foundation of this mall, have shaped many contemporary spiritual practices. From meditation and yoga to the pursuit of dharma and

moksha, they provide a profound roadmap for self-discovery. Just as you'd use a fitness app to track your health, the Vedas guide us in maintaining spiritual well-being in today's fast-paced world. Think of ethical living as maintaining cleanliness in your home. Vedas, like the principles of hygiene, provide a framework to create a harmonious and balanced life rooted in values like truth, nonviolence and self-discipline. As we grapple with global challenges like climate change and social inequality, the weights, much like a moral compass, guide us in making choices that foster sustainability equity and respect for all life forms. Preserving the Vedas is akin to safeguarding a family heirloom for future generations. Despite technological advancements like ebooks and online libraries, the traditional Vedic schools in India continue the age old practice of oral transmission, much like a grandfather narrating stories to his grandchildren. By ensuring this preservation, we keep the rich heritage alive, enabling future generations to engage with this ancient wisdom in their journey of understanding the world. So what are the universal messages which we can get from the Vedas? You have been trying to understand what was there in the Vedas, and we have seen that there were high moral values, there was a reliance on skill sets, and we have also seen the rutu, the disciplined life. So don't you think that all this is going to help us in our lives even now? If we become disciplined, if we believe in the discipline, won't our society and country progress even more than what we have today? There is a message of working hard to fulfill our goals. Is it not going to help us even now? And not only on that front, but all this is going to make us better human beings and better global citizens. So I would certainly say that all these principles and ideas which we see in the Vedas can be applied not only to our country but to the entire world. Like a favourite playlist that you return to time and again, the Vedas offer timeless teachings that remain relevant across ages. Their universal messages of unity, respect for nature, pursuit of knowledge, and ethical living resonate strongly in our modern world. As we reflect on these, it becomes clear that the weights, much like a mirror, help us to see the larger picture of life, encouraging us to live with wisdom, compassion and harmony. Namaste

Learning outcomes:

- 1] Understand the significance of the Vedic period.
- 2] Identify the major characteristics of the Vedic society.
- 3] Explain the composition and structure of the Vedas.

- 4] Recognize the key themes and teachings of each Ved.
- 5] Analyse the influence of the Vedas on society and culture.
- 6] Discuss the relevance of the Vedas in contemporary times.